

HOME

**A
Place**

**That
Not**

**Everyone
Has**

HOME

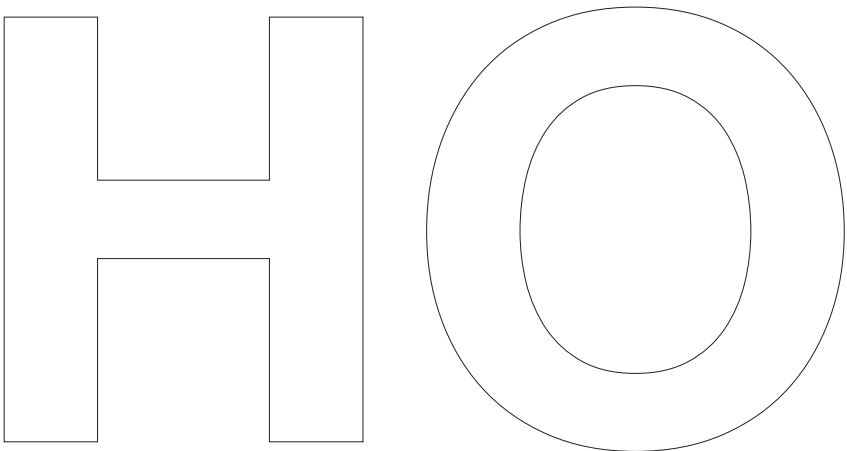
A place that not everyone has

Home, particularly the concept of a hometown, isn't universal. When most people envision home, they might picture the house they currently reside in. Yet, home could also evoke memories of a place where one has spent their entire life or where childhood memories were formed. It might be the street where you rode bicycles with friends, the movie theater you frequented with family on weekends, or the mall where you hung out after school. However, this narrative doesn't apply to everyone. When others reminisce about their hometowns, I often struggle to pinpoint where mine is, and I suspect many others share this sentiment. This book delves into the experiences of those without a defined hometown—their sense of displacement, the gaze of onlookers witnessing our absence, and the unexpected benefits of not having a fixed abode.

FINDING A PLACE FOR
THIRD-CULTURE KIDS IN THE CULTURE
By Noor Brara

THE WANDERER
Old English poem

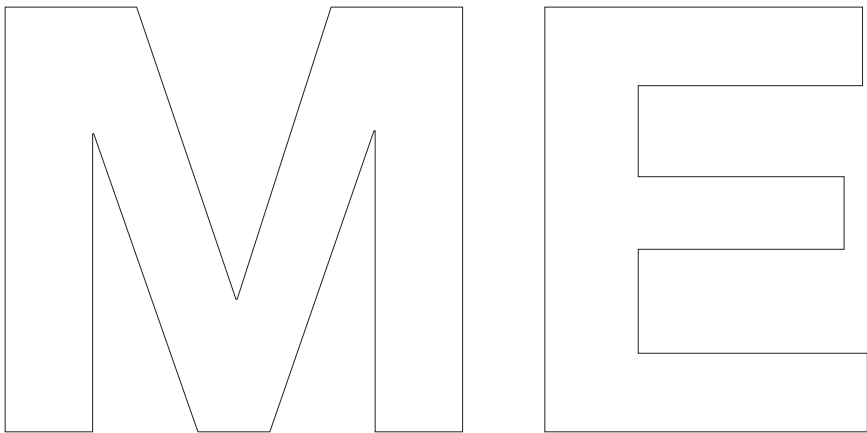
I DON'T HAVE A HOMETOWN IT'S THAUGHT ME A LOT
By Elia Rathore



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Finding a Place for Third-Culture Kids in the Culture

On a blanching, sun-baked afternoon, two teenagers, a boy and a girl, wander into a grocery store to pick up lunch. Fraser is a recent transplant from [REDACTED] and Britney a new friend who has lived her life evenly between [REDACTED], [REDACTED] and Italy, though you'd never know it by her [REDACTED] drawl or the pop music she blares through her headphones. To the viewer, the scene presents like quotidian life in the [REDACTED] — but for the fact that it takes place in [REDACTED], [REDACTED] on a military base where families work and attend school, their children running off every evening to dance and drink by the cerulean sea alongside their friends from town with whom they scheme and share secrets, whispered in fluent [REDACTED]. In a few years, many of them will ready themselves for a move — to another [REDACTED] on another military base in another country, with a supermarket configured to look exactly like this one. “They look the same so you don’t feel lost,” Britney tells Fraser. “Do you ever feel lost?” he asks. She shrugs.

What does it mean to be from everywhere and nowhere at once?

The idea that a sense of belonging is challenged by the straddling of cultures is hardly a revelation; nearly every maker whose back story was shaped by more than one place has arrived at some version of that conclusion. But rarely do we hear the stories of so-called “**third-culture kids**” and the private, nomadic worlds in which they are raised, marked by a certain shared disorientation and the sense that home is everywhere and nowhere at once. It’s for this reason that the Italian director Luca Guadagnino will attempt to unpack one iteration of this experience — through Fraser, Britney and their five best friends — in “**We Are Who We Are,**” an eight-part series premiering this September on HBO that pulls back the curtain on the experiences of the children of military families abroad and other third-culture kids like them, whose place in the world now feels both more tenuous and important than ever before.

Coined by the American sociologist Ruth Useem in the 1950s, the term “third-culture kid” was conceived for expatriate children who spend their formative years overseas, shaped by the multicultural, peripatetic spheres of their parents, many of whom are diplomats, military members or others working in foreign service. They relocate frequently and enroll their children in international schools, exposing them to miniature realms cultivated by peers from nations far and wide, whose customs, languages and mores coalesce, birthing hybrid or “third” cultures that are globe-spanning, diverse, highly empathic and oftentimes difficult to translate outside these environments.

TCK (THIRD CULTURE KIDS)

Third culture kids or third culture individuals are people who were raised in a culture other than their parents’ or the culture of their country of nationality, and also live in a different environment during a significant part of their child development years.

Perhaps because this life is characteristically slippery, it's struggled to become clearly defined in the culture, even in fictional stories, suited though they are to crafting imagined worlds. Ironically, while most TCKs cite the ability to relate to nearly everyone, their own narratives suffer a relatability problem, perhaps because their youthful experiences, relegated wholly to remembrance and recollection, are in many ways too singular and strange-seeming to others. Still, there are characters that have managed to catch hold, the complexities of their placelessness often anchored to more universal quandaries: Elio Perlman, played by Timothée Chalamet in Guadagnino's 2017 film adaptation of André Aciman's "Call Me By Your Name" is one such example; a trilingual adolescent reared in the university orbit between the United States and Northern Italy — his father is from the former, his mother the latter — he casts his American and European identities on and off with a kind of begrudging ease, lording them over his father's visiting graduate student, Oliver (Armie Hammer), on some days, while on others he's consumed by a sort of languid estrangement from everyone around him, retreating into himself. Though the story is propelled forward by the unfurling of muffled desire and fleeting boyhood, it's hard not to notice how a defined cultural identity — or lack thereof — inevitably underscores Elio's coming-of-age, as he pursues different versions of himself in different relationships: in English with Oliver, in French and Italian with his girlfriend Marzia and in all three with his parents, code-switching in what feels like a futile attempt to stitch together facets of a fractured self.

Of course, how Elio conveys this onscreen may have more to do with Guadagnino himself, who has long constructed his complex, layered characters partly in his own image. “That’s me,” he says immediately over Zoom in August, when I read off Useem’s definition of a third-culture kid.

“I was born in Palermo, and moved almost right away to Ethiopia. I spent the first six years of my life there. Then we went to Rome, then Palermo again and then back to Rome, then to Milan and to London. I feel the most important aspect of being a filmmaker is to be really aware of what forms you as much as what’s in front of you. So, I always try to keep in mind what I could have been experiencing during my youth in all these places through the prism of these complex stories I tell.”

I could define myself by my passions,
not my passport

Shape-shifting
becomes a
necessary
survival skill

If asked, any third-culture kid will tell you that shape-shifting — rousing one of the many selves stacked within you to best suit the place you're in — becomes a necessary survival skill, a sort of feigned fitting in that allows you to relate something of yourself to nearly everyone you meet. As someone raised between New York and the diplobrat bubble of an international school in New Delhi, India, where friends would come and go every few years, I became adept at calibrating myself to find the points of connection between us, able to relate equally to someone from South Korea, Iceland, Japan, Italy or Jamaica, in many cases more so than to other Indian Americans whose lives, at least on paper, read closer to my own. And because our stories couldn't be gleaned from our outward appearances, accents or possessions, we all came humble to the table, open and permeable and ready to barter the surfaces of our souls: our learnings, our languages, our cuisines, our clothing.

While all of this contributed, certainly, to feeling perennially adrift (according to multiple studies by Useem and others, much as they may try, adult TCKs never wholly repatriate culturally), it blotted the sensation of feeling like we'd

“grown up at an angle to everywhere and everyone,”

as the writer Pico Iyer — of Indian parentage, raised between England and California, who now lives between the latter and Japan — told me during a recent phone conversation. In his own work, Iyer has spent a lifetime examining this feeling and others that result from cultural crisscrossing, both out in the world in “Video Night in Kathmandu,” a 1988 collection of essays which examines the unlikely cultural points at which East and West meet across Asia — Japan’s affinity for baseball, say, or the Philippines’ obsession

with country and western music — and then in “The Global Soul,” written twelve years later, which studied, conversely, the crisscrossings that take place within. Iyer found peace in accepting that belonging had little to do with geography, but rather a collection of personal interests, ideas and relationships accumulated over time.

“Growing up with three cultures around or inside me, I felt that I could define myself by my passions, not my passport,”

he says. “In some ways, I would never be Indian or English or Californian, and that was quite freeing, though people may always define me by my skin color or accent. But also, because I didn’t have that external way of defining myself, I had to be really rigorous and directed in grounding myself internally, through my values and loyalties and to the people I hold closest to me.”

Others have found freedom in the same, becoming natural shape-shifters whose value systems transcend borders to instill a sense of home.

The most famous example is probably Barack Obama, whose 1995 memoir, “Dreams From My Father: A Story of Race and Inheritance,” whirls through Jakarta, Seattle, Kenya and Hawaii with unsparing analysis of what it means to belong to multiple worlds and therefore to none of them, but to find, later, that refuge lies in the space between all of them — and in the ability to unite not just your worlds but others’, too. As much as the third-culture experience is clouded by the fog of liminality, it’s informed also by the ability to define oneself on one’s own terms, difficult as that endeavor may be in the face of increasing scrutiny toward globalism and those formed by it.

The presentation of this — dazzling and dressed up — is what makes “We Are Who We Are” thrilling to watch. Its characters come alive in the blur, filling in one another’s spaces and dancing over questions of home, while bragging about where they’ve been, their exchanges captured in shimmering, slow-motion interludes scored to original music, the silky synth pop of Blood Orange. And while the show takes place in the run-up to the 2016 election, its politics remain a quiet drumbeat in the offing, its spotlight focused wholly on all the ways by which differences are, in fact, paradoxically harmonious when everyone is otherized. In fashioning themselves to evade traditional modes of identification (culturally, politically, sexually and through gender), these characters build their own castles in the sky. “When you grow up this way, there is a feeling of being lost, but to be lost is also to be open,” Guadagnino says. “It reminds us of our empathy, and of what we share if we were only to try and find it.”

This may be the ultimate lesson of third-culture kids' stories. In the late Kobe Bryant's 2018 book "The Mamba Mentality," which offers a glimpse into his childhood years in Reggio Emilia, Italy, he discusses the importance of having learned how to navigate a new culture with compassion. Though he eventually settled down in America — becoming not only one of its sports heroes, but one of its cultural icons, too — he continued to make frequent trips back to Italy, where he'd speak the sort of Italian that boasted a native European bravado, a casual swagger that rode along his perfect pronunciation. And when he died in Los Angeles, he died in Reggio Emilia, too, where they mourned a version of him America never knew, except for the Italian names he had chosen for his daughters: Gianna, Natalia, Bianka and Capri.

Of course, not all depictions of third-culture life have been so uplifting.

Occasionally, too, these characters are written to be spoofed and ridiculed, assigned snobbish attitudes and superiority complexes. Without proper context, it can appear as if they need too much and require a sort of excess to keep them perpetually moving, making it hard to divorce third-culture life from that of overt wealth and privilege, or an indifference to local customs. In the 2018 Netflix show “You,” the model-actress Hari Nef portrays Blythe, a third-culture poet prodigy whose parents worked for the state department and raised her between Papua New Guinea and Tokyo. When the central character, Beck — a timid, hopeful writer played by Elizabeth Lail — meets her, she looks her up and down and smirks before asking, “Jersey, right?” and runs off to take a call from her grandparents in Swedish. In the third-culture writer Stephanie LaCava’s forthcoming novel, “The Superrationals,” which dives into the torrid waters of the international art world, the protagonist Mathilde, raised between the U.S. and France, is ridiculed relentlessly by “the girls,” a catty clique of gallery insiders who dislike her for all the ways in which she’s different (“What is that name?” they ask. “Is she even French? She’s so pretentious”). And in 2010’s “Sidewalks,” a razor-sharp

collection of essays about the failures of finding home in lived experiences and written ones alike, Valeria Luiselli — the author of the 2019 novel “Lost Children Archive” and the daughter of a Mexican diplomat formed by an upbringing in Costa Rica, South Korea, India and South Africa — sarcastically comments on her own selection of Mexico as “her country,” driven mostly by cynicism and

“a sort of spiritual laziness than an authentic act of faith.”

She admits she’s never felt true allegiance to anywhere she’s lived, knowing only that she must continue roaming.

But all these stories, of course, predate the precarious state we find ourselves in today,

when borders are clamping down in domino effect, driven in part by the Covid-19 pandemic, itself a case against globalism and the speed at which interconnectedness can burn it all down, imperiling not only our ability to travel but limiting those who find selfhood in marginal spaces, whose stories underscore the urgency of seeing the world as one. And while internationalism deserves examination, what we stand to lose without it is our ability to lift one another up, to find each other in the in-between. One might look to Kamala Harris — who, born to Jamaican and Indian parents, often discusses her ability to consider multiple sides — or Obama before her. Such voices, with their chameleonic stories and sensibilities, help locate the light in the dark.

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Were you lost?

The Wanderer

"How often the lone-dweller anticipates
some sign, this Measurer's mercy
– must always must–
mind-caring, along the ocean's windings,
stirring rime-chill seas, hands as oars
many long whiles, treading the tracks of exile–
the way of the world an open book always." (1-5)

So spoke the earth-stepper, a memorial of miseries
slaughter of the wrathful, crumbling of kinsmen:

"Often, every daybreak, alone I must
bemoan my cares. There's now no one living
to whom I dare mumble my mind's understanding.
I know as truth that it's seen suitable
for anyone to bind fast their spirit's closet,
hold onto the hoards, think whatever – (8-14)

"Can a weary mind weather the shitstorm?
I think not.
Can a roiling heart set itself free?
I don't think so.

So often those hustling for the win must
clamp down grim mindings in their coffer,
just as I ought fetter my inborn conceit,
often wounded, wanting where I know,
kindred pulled away, how many winters now?
I shrouded my giver in dark earth
and wended away worrisome,
weather-watching the wrapful waves,
hall-wretched, seeking a center,
far or near, where they might be found,
in some mead-hall, who knows of my kind,
willing to adopt a friendless me,
though they be joyful enough. (15-29a)

"The well-travelled know how slicing
sorrow can be by one's side,
short a struggle-friend, however dear.
The ways of wandering wind him round
not even a wire of wound gold–
a frigid fastness, hardly any fruits of the fold.
This one lists the hall-lads swilling rings,
giver-drenched in youngsome days,
in both furnishing and feasting.
Joys all flown, vanished all away! (29b-36)

"Therefore one knows who long forgoes
the friendly words of their first,
when sleep and sorrow stand together
clutching at the crestfallen alone.
Somehow seems that somewhere inside
this one enwraps his lord and kisses his lord,

and laps both hands and head
on his knee, when, once upon a year
blurry in time now, one thrived by the throne –
too soon rousing, a friendless singular
seeing all around a fallowness of waves,
sea-birds bathing, fanning their feathers,
ice and snow hurtling, heaved up with hail. (37-48)

“So heavy and heavier the hurt in heart
harrowing for the lost. Sorrow made new
whenever recalling pervades the mind,
greeting kindred joyfully, drinking in the look of them
fellowable and fathoming –

they always swim away.
Gulls ghost-call – I don’t know their tongue too well,
much of their comfort weird. Worrying made new
to that one who must send more and more, every day,
a bleary soul back across the binding of waves. (49-57)

“Therefore I cannot wonder across this world
why my mind does not muster in the murk
when I ponder pervading all the lives of humans,
how suddenly they abandon their halls,
proud princes and young. Right here in the middle
it fumbles and falls every day – (58-63)

“No one can be wise before earning their lot of winters
in this world. The wise one, they stay patient:
not too heart-heated, not so hasty to harp,
not too weak-armed, nor too wan-headed,
nor too fearful nor too fey nor too fee-felching,
and never tripping the tongue too much, before it trips them. (64-9)

“That one bides their moment to make brag,
until the inner fire seizes its moment clearly,
to where their secret self veers them.

Who’s wise must fore-ken how ghostly it has been
when the world and its things stand wasted –
like you find, here and there, in this middle space now –
there walls totter, wailed around by winds,
gnashed by frost, the buildings snow-lapt.
The winehalls molder, their wielder lies
washed clean of joys, his peerage all perished,
proud by the wall. War ravaged a bunch
ferried along the forth-way, others a raptor ravished
over lofty seas, this one the hoary wolf
broke in its banes, the last a brother
graveled in the ground, tears as war-mask. (70-84)

“That’s the way it goes –
the Shaper mills middle-earth to waste
until they stand empty, the giants’ work and ancient,
drained of the dreams and joys of its dwellers.” (85-7)

Then one wisely regards this wall-stead,
deliberates a darkened existence,
aged in spirit, often remembering from afar
many war-slaughterings, and speaks these words: (88-91)

“Where has the horse gone?
Where are my kindred?
Where is the giver of treasure?
Where are the benches to bear us?
Joys of the hall to bring us together?
No more, the bright goblet!
All gone, the mailed warrior!
Lost for good, the pride of princes!

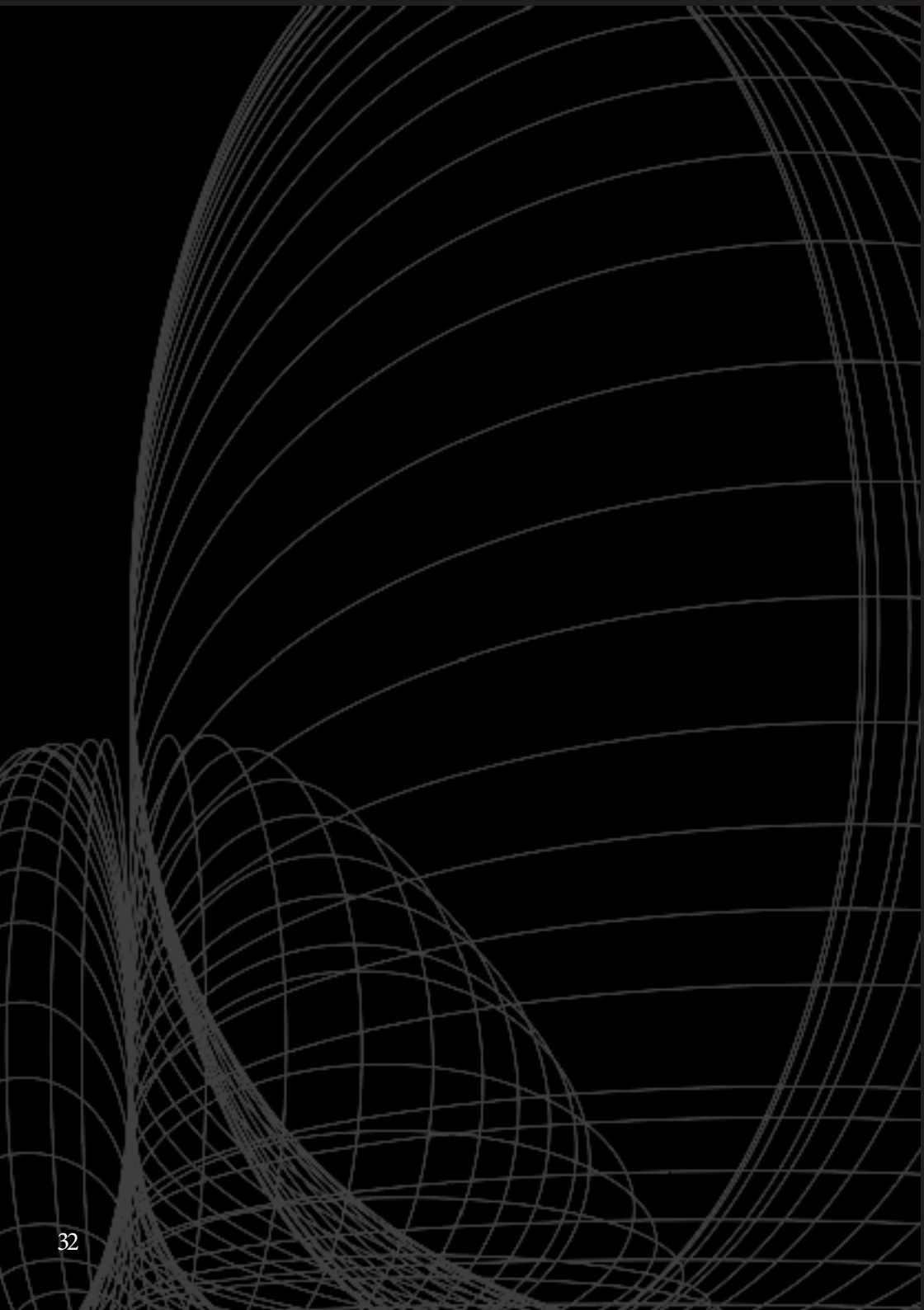
“How the space of years has spread –
growing gloomy beneath the night-helm,
as if it never was! (92-6)

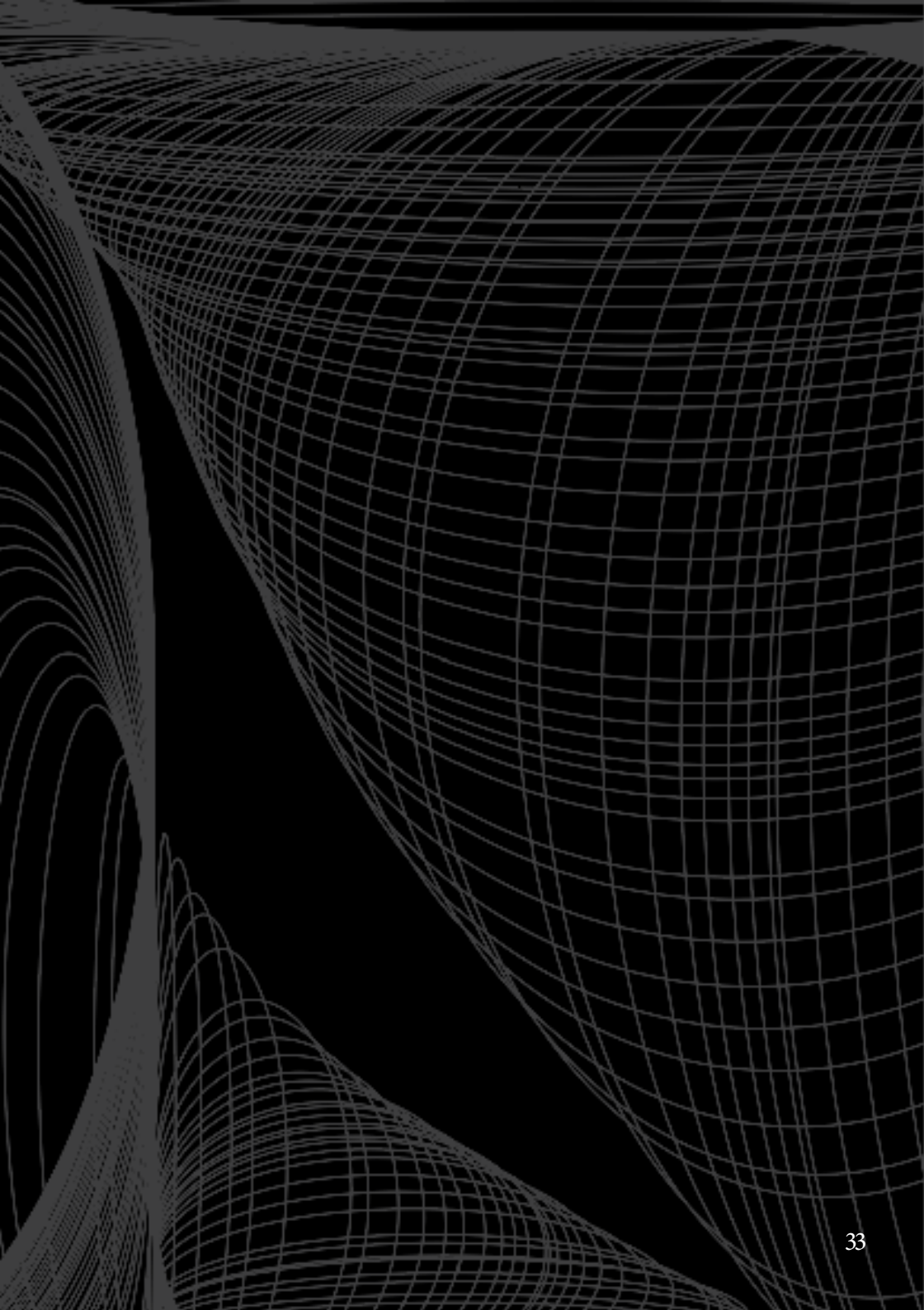
“Tracks of the beloved multitude, all that remains
walls wondrous tall, serpents seething –
thanes stolen, pillaged by ashen foes
gear glutting for slaughter – we know this world’s way,
and the storms still batter these stony cliffs.
The tumbling snows stumble up the earth,
the clash of winter, when darkness descends.
Night-shadows benighten, sent down from the north,
raw showers of ice, who doesn’t hate humanity? (97-105)

All shot through in misery in earthly realms,
fortune’s turn turns the world under sky.
Here the cash was a loan.
Your friends were a loan.
Anyone at all, a loan.
Your family only ever a loan –
And this whole foundation of the earth wastes away!” (106-10)

So says the wise one, you don’t hear him at all,
sitting apart reading their own runes. (111)
It’s better to clutch at your counsel,
you ought never manifest your miseries
not too quickly where they well,
unless the balm is clear beforehand,
keep whittling at your courage. (112-14a)

It will be well for those who seek the favor,
the comfort from our father in heaven,
where a battlement bulwarks us all. (114b-5)





However, we are not always LOST.

Not having a home means ANYWHERE can be HOME.

I Don't Have a Hometown. It's Taught Me a Lot.

I've never decorated my bedroom before. For me, the act of adorning a room with little trinkets, putting up posters, and all the things associated with making a place my own always seemed futile. Even during the four years I spent living in a dorm, I never saw the point. This is all just temporary, I thought.

I had bedrooms in 10 different countries growing up. My parents are Pakistani diplomats, so my siblings and I have had an unconventional life. I was born in Egypt, and then lived in the United Arab Emirates, Pakistan, Philippines, Thailand, Bangladesh, the United States and Germany.

Moving around so much makes me a “Third Culture Kid,” or TCK. The term was coined by sociologist Ruth Hill Useem in the 1950s to describe children who live in countries foreign to their parents, and thus occupy a position between the culture of their parents and the culture of the country in which they live.

Ask most TCKs, and they'll say we're lucky. When you're forced to be the new kid at school enough times, you come up with an algorithm to fit in. It became second nature to lay low at first, discern the unspoken rules of the school, and then fake it to the best of my ability.

Growing up in 10 different countries
wasn't easy.

When I first moved to the United States, I had a lot to learn. For one, I was used to wearing a uniform to school; now I had to pick an outfit everyday. Not wanting to appear different, I sat in the library on my first day and just kind of looked at people. (I quickly realized that athleisure was the way to go.)

Like an ethnographer-in-training, I honed my observational skills over the years and became a cultural chameleon. You'll notice this in a lot of TCKs, the ability to negotiate between cultures and mediate between diverse groups of people. But every silver lining has a cloud.

The longing I feel for cities and places is peculiar and gnawing. You can't text a city and tell her you miss her vibe. I have extensive memories of Ampang Park, a

shopping mall near our condo in Malaysia. Thinking about the park triggers flashes of Archie comics, pirated DVDs, my first ever Red Hot Chili Peppers album, and the nasi goreng I'd sometimes try to convince my dad to get on our way home from school. This year, they tore it down. I had tears in my eyes when I heard the news. When we left Kuala Lumpur, I told myself I'd come back one day to the city that partially raised me, to my temporary home, to my Ampang Park. However, as I would learn, some goodbyes are more irrevocable than others. Looming above every new beginning was its ending. With every friend I made, I knew I'd have to have a long-distance relationship at some point. Every time we unpacked, I wondered what I'd be packing next time. Every time I entered an airport, I knew I'd leave from the same place. Memory became precious, knowing that sometimes that's all I'd have left of a place.

HOME, a place that everyone has.

While some TCKs lament the loss of a home, of stability, I feel like the perpetual state of transition taught me that one can have many homes. Sometimes you find home in people, and sometimes homes can be temporary. Now that I'm in a gap year after college, headfirst in the throes of post-collegiate disillusionment, I see

lessons from my life coming into play. Being in this state of limbo is difficult, but very familiar. Liminal spaces aren't so scary when you've occupied them for most of your life. In fact, I feel right at home.

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